Messiah's arrival, a day when kings marched into their own cities in triumph.

France was hardly in a state of victory, though. The devastation of the civil war lingered. Charles VII's previous royalist soldiers formed robber bands called *écorcheurs* (the "skinners," or "flayers") and stormed the countryside; it took the Constable a long time to bring them under control.

Charles VII created an additional disturbance by reorganizing the army. With the cooperation of the Estates-General at Orleans, he decreed that from now on, a permanent, government-controlled army would defend France. All officers were under the direction of the king, and no French duke could have soldiers of his own without the permission of the king. It was the end of private armies, a strike against one of the most treasured privileges of the French aristocracy.

Some of the dukes resisted. They joined forces with the *écorcheurs* and tried to mount an armed rebellion. But the government army, under the direction of the Constable of France, squelched the resistance before it could flower: the first demonstration of the new French military might.[20]

By this point, the English had lost almost all their French territories. In 1444, young Henry VI—now twenty–three and in control of his own government—agreed to a temporary cease-fire; he also consented to marry Charles VII's niece Margaret, a wedding that took place in 1445.

But the union did not save the last English territories. In June of 1449, Charles VII abruptly accused the English of failing to abide by the terms of the cease-fire, and of attempting to incite the French Duke of Brittany, Charles's nephew, to rebellion against the crown of France. In a series of campaigns between July 31, 1449, and August 22, 1451, the French army reconquered almost every fortress, town, and strategic position in both Normandy and Gascony, the latter English-held for the last three hundred years. Henry VI promised to send reinforcements, but he was preoccupied with domestic matters (a series of court intrigues and plots against him) and never managed to get the ships launched. Finally, the only English territory remaining in France was now a tiny strip encompassing Calais and Guînes. "Thus were the Englishmen clearly displaced," Holinshed mourns, "and lost the possession of all the countries, towns, castles, and places within the realm of France . . . continually losing and nothing gaining."[21]

Not all of Normandy was pleased with Charles VII's rule, especially since he now imposed new taxes to pay for all the fighting. In October of 1452, citizens of Bordeaux ("already wearied of the French servitude") allowed an English army of five thousand to land there under the command of John Talbot, son of the Earl of Shrewsbury. The French army arrived with cannon —the first time it had made use of cannon in a siege—and cut the English